

WORKING TOWARD INDEPENDENCE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Develop a program of recovery and increase knowledge of community resources.
2. Demonstrate increased organization of and attention to daily routines resulting in personal responsibilities being fulfilled.
3. Identify relevant community resources and ways to access them for help with independent activities of daily living (IADLs).
4. Take responsibility for own IADLs up to the level of the client's potential and develop resources for obtaining help from others.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE SELF-CARE DEFICITS—SECONDARY

- Assessing My Needs
- Assessing Self-Care Deficits
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Thought Disorders
- Filling In the Gaps
- How Independent Am I?
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Relating Self-Care Deficits to My Addiction
- Using My Support Network

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Attention Deficit Disorder, Inattentive Type (ADD)
- Attention Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)
- Dependent Traits
- Psychosis
- Self-Care Deficits—Primary

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Working toward Independence” exercise is designed to help clients who may not be accustomed to seeking help or know how to find and use healthy community resources. Follow-up may include making appropriate referrals and/or guiding the client in investigating resources in his/her community and practicing specific skills in gaining access to them.

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Addictive lifestyles have a negative impact on personal independence. Continuing in an addictive lifestyle can interfere with effectively carrying out independent activities of daily living (e.g., banking, shopping, interacting with others, responding to crisis, organizational skills, utilizing community resources) and can ultimately undermine a person's ability to live independently. This exercise asks you to take an inventory of your independent daily living skills and will help you make some decisions about areas on which you can begin to work.

1. What positive and negative experiences have you had with your day-to-day activities of independent living while you've been actively engaging in your addiction?

2. What are three ways in which your addiction threatens your personal independence?

3. What problems have you had because you neglected or avoided daily living tasks or relied on others to do them for you while addicted?

4. What do you see as the benefits of personally taking responsibility for carrying out daily living tasks in healthy and adaptive ways?

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5. If you've done the exercise titled "Filling in the Gaps," you identified areas of your life where you believe there are deficits. Do you know what resources in your community could provide you some help in these areas? _____ With which are you familiar, how will they help you, and which ones do you need help locating?

6. Of the resources you know, do you use them consistently and when you need them? If not, what interferes (e.g., finances, transportation, day care)?

7. After identifying your deficit areas and the resources that could help you with them, think about what personal barriers affect your willingness or ability to follow through (e.g., communication skills, confidence, fear). Please use this space to list them.

8. Choose one of the barriers you've identified in question 7. With the help of your therapist, develop a step-by-step plan to begin to face and overcome that barrier. Briefly describe your plan here.

Especially in early recovery, the details of managing day-to-day living, personally healing, and resolving the difficulties created by your past addictive behavior can seem overwhelming. It is important to prioritize things, take things a step at a time, and ask for help when you need it.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.